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CHAPTER 03

Understanding Stress and Healthy Coping Strategies

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About this chapter

Stress is part of human life, but its effects are not always simple. This chapter explains what stress is, why it happens, how it affects the body and mind, how people can respond to it safely, and when additional support matters. It includes realistic situations, activities readers can try or skip, and knowledge questions with explanations.

Learning outcomes

- Explain how a stress response differs from a stressor, and why stress does not always signal illness.
- Identify emotional, physical, cognitive, behavioral, and social changes that may accompany stress.
- Distinguish manageable short-term stress from prolonged distress that deserves extra support.
- Apply several flexible coping skills without blaming oneself for difficult circumstances.
- Recognize warning signs indicating the need for professional or urgent medical support.

How to use: Read in order or return to the relevant section. Exercises are invitations, not tests. If any activity is uncomfortable, stop and choose another approach. People in unsafe environments may need practical protection and assistance, not only stress-management techniques.

1. What stress means

Stress is a state of worry or mental tension that arises in response to a difficult or demanding situation. It can involve thoughts, emotions, changes in the body, and actions. The situation itself is

called a stressor; the way our mind and body respond is the stress response. Two people may face a similar situation but experience different levels of stress because their needs, resources, health, history, and support differ. [1]

Stress is not proof of weakness. People may feel stressed when they care deeply about something, face uncertainty, struggle with practical needs, or live through circumstances that exceed their available resources. Even positive changes, such as starting a new job or welcoming a child, can require adjustment.

How the stress response works

When the brain detects a possible challenge or threat, the body can become more alert. Breathing, heart rate, attention, and muscle tension may change. This response can prepare a person to act. After the situation passes, the body may gradually return toward a calmer state. When challenges continue or feel inescapable, high alertness and mental strain may persist, affecting wellbeing.

The body’s response is not always proportional to actual danger. Thoughts, memories, uncertainty, physical illness, and ongoing hardship can all influence how a person reacts. This is why understanding the context is more helpful than telling someone simply to “stop worrying.”

> Remember: Some stress can sharpen attention for a short task. Too much stress, especially for a prolonged period, can affect health and daily functioning. The goal is not to eliminate every stress response; it is to improve safety, support, recovery, and flexible coping. [1]

2. Common sources of stress

Stress can arise in one part of life or build up across several areas. Naming the pressure is often a first step toward deciding whether the situation needs practical action, emotional support, or both.

Life area	Examples of possible stressors
Learning and work	Examinations, workload, uncertainty about performance, unemployment, workplace conflict
Family and relationships	Arguments, caregiving demands, loneliness, separation, difficulties setting boundaries
Money and basic needs	Debt, unstable income, food insecurity, housing or transport difficulties
Health	Illness, pain, lack of sleep, supporting an unwell family member
Environment and community	Displacement, discrimination, unsafe surroundings, community crises, unpredictable events
Life changes	Bereavement, moving home, changing schools, becoming a parent

These examples are not diagnoses. A person may experience several stressors at once. Some can be changed with planning or support; others are shaped by systemic problems or unsafe conditions

that require services, community action, or protection beyond the individual.

3. Recognizing stress in everyday life

Stress affects people differently. The signs below may appear alone or together. They may also be caused by health conditions, medication effects, sleep deprivation, or other factors, so they should not be used as a self-diagnosis.

Area	Possible experiences
Emotions	Irritability, worry, frustration, fear, sadness, feeling overwhelmed
Thinking	Racing thoughts, difficulty focusing, indecision, repeatedly imagining worst-case outcomes
Body	Muscle tension, headache, upset stomach, fatigue, sleep changes, faster heartbeat
Behavior	Avoiding tasks, working without breaks, withdrawal, changes in eating, increased substance use
Relationships	Short temper, conflict, reduced patience, less interest in social contact

Stress can create a cycle

Imagine someone worried about a deadline. They sleep poorly, so concentrating becomes harder. Slower progress increases worry, which then interferes with sleep again. The person may conclude that they are incapable, even though the cycle is partly driven by exhaustion and pressure. Breaking the cycle can begin with a realistic task plan, rest, or asking for help rather than more self-criticism.

If a symptom is new, persistent, severe, or medically concerning, do not assume stress explains it. A healthcare professional can help investigate possible causes.

4. Short-term stress and long-lasting stress

Short-term stress can appear in response to an immediate demand and ease as the demand passes. For example, a learner may feel tense before a presentation and gradually relax afterward. It can still feel intense and may warrant support.

Prolonged stress occurs when significant pressure continues over time or recovery is limited. A caregiver facing repeated responsibilities with little rest may develop exhaustion, irritability, difficulty sleeping, or trouble managing daily tasks. Persistent stress is not a separate diagnosis by itself, but it may increase the need for practical, social, or professional support.

The important questions are not only “How long has this lasted?” but also “How intense is it?”, “How is it affecting daily life?”, “Is the person safe?”, and “What support is available?”

5. Stress, anxiety, depression, and burnout: not the same thing

Stress describes a response to demands or perceived threats. Anxiety often involves worry or fear about possible future danger. Depression is a mental health condition involving a characteristic pattern of mood and other symptoms. Burnout is described by WHO as an occupational phenomenon linked to chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed; it is not a medical condition on its own. These experiences can overlap, but a short article cannot determine which applies to a person.

When symptoms are ongoing, worsening, or interfere with functioning, a qualified healthcare professional can consider mental and physical health explanations, the person's context, and appropriate care.

6. Understanding what you can and cannot control

One useful way to respond to stress is to separate the stressor from the actions available to you. This does not mean accepting injustice or blaming yourself for problems outside your control. It means choosing practical steps while acknowledging limits.

You may be able to influence	You may not be able to control directly
Preparing a small study schedule	Another person's decisions or opinions
Asking a trusted person for help	The wider economy or sudden price changes
Taking a break or requesting reasonable support	Every outcome of an interview or examination
Seeking appropriate services	A past event or an unsafe person's behavior

A four-question problem-solving pause

- What exactly is happening? Describe the situation without blaming yourself.
- Which part needs immediate attention for safety or basic needs?
- What is one small action within my reach, and who might support it?
- What can wait, and what would require professional or community assistance?

7. Healthy coping: more than relaxation

Coping includes the thoughts, behaviors, relationships, and resources people use when facing challenges. Some strategies help reduce immediate tension; others address the problem causing it. Often both types are needed.

Problem-focused coping

When a difficulty can be changed, consider breaking it into smaller tasks, asking for clarification, arranging transport or childcare, talking with an appropriate service provider, or requesting

reasonable help. The aim is progress, not perfect control.

Emotion-focused coping

When feelings are intense, gentle grounding, paced rest, meaningful activities, supportive conversation, and compassionate self-talk may help a person respond more deliberately. These skills do not make an unsafe situation safe or replace practical solutions.

Support-focused coping

Some situations become more manageable when we are not alone. Useful support might be a trusted friend, teacher, family member, community health worker, healthcare professional, or relevant service. A trusted person is someone who respects privacy, boundaries, and safety; not every relative or authority figure is automatically safe to approach.

Coping behaviors that may create new problems

People may turn to alcohol, other substances, excessive avoidance, or repeated conflict when distressed. These responses may offer brief relief but can add health, financial, relationship, or safety difficulties. Respond with understanding rather than shame, and seek appropriate support if a pattern is difficult to change.

8. Practical exercise A: grounding in the present

Grounding is an attention skill that can be useful when thoughts or feelings become overwhelming. The following short activity is original educational wording informed by the grounding principles in WHO's Doing What Matters in Times of Stress. It is not a verbatim WHO protocol. [2]

- Choose: If you are somewhere reasonably safe, decide whether you would like to try. You may keep your eyes open.
- Notice: Look around slowly and identify a few ordinary details, such as a wall, a chair, a doorway, or sounds you can hear.
- Connect: If comfortable, feel the chair supporting you or your feet touching the ground. You do not need to change your breathing.
- Name: Quietly acknowledge "I am noticing worry" or "I am feeling tense," without judging the feeling.
- Return: Decide on one small, safe action you want to take next, even if the feeling has not disappeared.

> Safety note: Some people find body-focused or sensory exercises uncomfortable, particularly after frightening experiences. If distress increases, stop, orient toward a safe object or person, or use a different coping approach. Do not practise while driving or doing something that needs your full attention.

9. Practical exercise B: noticing and unhooking from thoughts

Under stress, the mind may repeat statements such as “I will fail,” “Nobody can help,” or “Everything is my fault.” These thoughts can feel like facts, especially when emotions are strong. The WHO-informed skill of unhooking means noticing difficult thoughts without automatically acting on them. [2]

- Identify one stressful thought without trying to force it away.
- Add a noticing phrase: “I am having the thought that I cannot cope.”
- Observe whether the thought is pushing you toward an action that harms or helps you.
- Choose one action consistent with what matters to you, such as taking a short break, requesting information, or speaking with a safe person.

This does not require denying real danger or minimizing valid concerns. If the thought is pointing to a genuine risk, the appropriate response may be to seek protection or practical assistance.

10. Practical exercise C: a manageable daily routine

Predictable routines can support wellbeing, especially when many things feel uncertain. WHO recommends regular meals, sleep, movement, and time for connection and rest as part of stress management. [1] The routine must be flexible and realistic for the person’s living conditions.

Moment	A flexible example
Morning	Drink water if available, identify today’s one essential task, notice how you feel
During the day	Pause briefly between demanding tasks; ask for clarification when needed
Late afternoon	Walk or move in a comfortable way, or rest if exhausted
Evening	Reduce stimulating activities when possible, connect with a trusted person, prepare for sleep

A person working long hours, sharing a crowded home, or caring for children may not be able to follow an ideal schedule. Small adjustments still count; basic needs and safety take priority over a perfect routine.

11. Practical exercise D: two-column stress journal

This exercise can help organize a problem rather than holding every worry in your mind. It should remain private. Avoid writing identifying details if someone else may access the page or device.

What is weighing on me?	One possible response or source of support
Example: I am worried about a school fee.	Ask the school about options; speak with a safe support person; plan what information to gather.
My own example: _____	Possible next step: _____
My own example: _____	Possible next step: _____

Writing is optional. Some people prefer thinking quietly, drawing, or talking to a trusted person. Stop if writing increases distress and seek support as appropriate.

12. Everyday examples and guided responses

Scenario A: examination pressure

A student has several assessments in one week. They feel worried, sleep late, and keep rereading the same page. Instead of interpreting this as laziness, the student identifies exhaustion and pressure. They divide revision into short, realistic blocks, ask a teacher which material is most important, and make space for sleep. If distress remains severe or school functioning worsens, they speak with a trusted adult or healthcare provider.

Scenario B: financial uncertainty

An adult in Kigali is worried because income has become unpredictable. They feel ashamed and avoid friends. The pressure is partly a real economic problem; breathing exercises alone will not resolve it. A supportive response may combine emotional support, practical budgeting help, trusted social connections, and available community or financial services. The person should not be blamed for feeling stressed.

Scenario C: caregiver overload

A person caring for an unwell relative begins to feel irritable and exhausted. They may need scheduled relief, shared responsibilities, a healthcare conversation, or assistance with transport and appointments. A brief rest can help, but long-term support must address the care burden itself.

Scenario D: conflict at work

A worker receives repeated harsh criticism and starts dreading each day. They might document concerns privately, review workplace support options, and seek advice from a trusted person. If there is harassment or danger, safety and practical remedies matter more than teaching the worker to tolerate the situation.

13. Supporting someone who is stressed

An effective first response is to listen, take the person seriously, and ask what kind of help would be useful. Avoid assuming that you know the cause or the solution. Respect the person’s choices and privacy.

- Say: “That sounds difficult. Would you like to talk, or would practical help be more useful?”
- Ask before giving advice, touching, involving other people, or sharing their story.
- Offer specific help you can realistically provide, such as accompanying them to a service.
- Avoid: “Others have it worse,” “Just be positive,” or “You are overreacting.”
- Encourage professional help if problems persist, worsen, or affect functioning.

If a person is unsafe or in immediate danger, prioritize emergency and appropriate professional assistance. Do not promise absolute secrecy when urgent safety action may be necessary; explain

privacy limits honestly.

14. When self-help is not enough

Self-help skills can be useful, but persistent or severe distress may require healthcare and practical support. Consider contacting a qualified healthcare professional when stress causes ongoing sleep difficulties, major changes in functioning, persistent physical symptoms, increased reliance on substances, or symptoms that are becoming harder to manage. [1, 3]

Seek urgent medical assessment for alarming physical symptoms such as severe chest pain, severe breathing difficulty, collapse, or sudden confusion. Do not assume these are due to stress. If someone may imminently harm themselves or another person, obtain immediate local emergency or healthcare assistance and remain with them if it is safe to do so.

For users in Rwanda, refer to locally verified health facilities and service pathways. This chapter intentionally does not print unverified helpline numbers. The final published version should include checked, current contact details and clear instructions suitable for the user’s location.

15. Stress and different life circumstances

Children and adolescents

Young people may show stress through changes in behavior, sleep, learning, irritability, or withdrawal. Adults should listen with curiosity, provide predictable support where possible, and avoid punishment for symptoms that may signal distress. Any concerns about safety, serious impairment, or prolonged symptoms deserve age-appropriate professional assessment.

Older adults and people with medical conditions

Stress can interact with pain, mobility challenges, loneliness, and medical treatment. New symptoms should be medically evaluated. Support may need to consider accessibility, medication schedules, transportation, and caregiver involvement only with appropriate consent.

People experiencing adversity

For people facing poverty, displacement, discrimination, or unsafe living conditions, coping guidance must not imply that the burden lies entirely with them. Immediate needs such as food, shelter, protection, physical healthcare, and reliable social support may be central to mental wellbeing.

16. Guided reflection and a seven-day practice plan

Choose only the activities that fit your circumstances. This is an optional learning plan, not a prescribed treatment or a test of success.

Day	Small, flexible practice
1	Notice one stress sign and one possible source of pressure.

Day	Small, flexible practice
2	Identify one thing you can influence and one thing outside your control.
3	Try brief grounding if comfortable; stop if distress increases.
4	Reach out to one safe person or helpful service, if appropriate.
5	Choose one small adjustment that supports sleep, food, movement, or rest.
6	Notice one recurring thought and practise responding without self-criticism.
7	Review what helped, what did not, and whether further support is needed.

Reflection questions

- What do I notice first when I begin to feel stressed?
- Which pressures are practical problems, and which feelings need attention?
- What is one unhelpful response I use when overwhelmed? What could I try instead?
- Who, if anyone, is safe and reliable for me to approach?
- What sign would tell me that I should seek professional care?

17. Knowledge check with explained answers

Q1. Is stress always a mental illness?
Answer: No. Stress is a common response to difficult situations. It can be harmful when intense or prolonged, but it is not automatically a diagnosis.

Q2. Can stress produce physical symptoms?
Answer: Yes. Tension, sleep changes, and stomach discomfort may occur. However, physical symptoms can also have medical causes and sometimes need urgent assessment.

Q3. Is telling someone to relax enough when the problem is unsafe housing or loss of income?
Answer: No. Coping skills may support wellbeing but do not replace practical support, protection, and solutions to material needs.

Q4. What should you do if grounding makes you feel more distressed?
Answer: Stop. Choose a different activity, move attention toward something safer, and seek support if needed.

Q5. When should someone speak with a healthcare professional?
Answer: When symptoms persist, worsen, significantly affect daily life, involve concerning physical symptoms, or feel difficult to manage; urgent danger needs immediate assistance.

18. Glossary and key messages

Term	Meaning
Stressor	A situation or demand that may trigger stress.
Stress response	Changes in mind and body related to a perceived challenge or threat.
Grounding	Bringing attention toward present surroundings or sensations in a manageable way.
Unhooking	Noticing a difficult thought rather than automatically following it.
Coping	Actions and resources used to respond to difficulties.
Professional support	Assessment or care from an appropriately qualified provider.

Five messages to take away:

1. Stress is human and does not indicate weakness.
2. Stress can influence thoughts, feelings, physical health, and relationships.
3. Practical problem-solving and emotional coping often work best together.
4. Not every coping technique suits every person; safety and choice matter.
5. Seeking support is appropriate before stress becomes unbearable.

References and editorial note

[1] World Health Organization. Stress. Questions and answers, 30 March 2026. https://www.who.int/news-room/questions-and-answers/item/stress

[2] World Health Organization. Doing What Matters in Times of Stress: An Illustrated Guide. 2020. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240003927

[3] World Health Organization. Psychological self-help interventions: delivering self-help for individuals, featuring Step-by-Step and Doing What Matters in Times of Stress. 1 June 2026. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240120785

Editorial note: The exercises and examples in this chapter are newly written educational adaptations informed by the above public-health sources. They are not represented as official WHO exercises, a translated WHO manual, or a validated treatment protocol. Review source licensing and permission conditions before reproducing or formally adapting any source materials.

Before publication: Obtain review from a qualified mental health professional; check safety and age appropriateness; validate locally relevant examples and Kinyarwanda/French terminology; confirm current Rwanda referral information; test accessibility and comprehension.